HU5175 Education, Technology, and Society

Assignment 3C
Mobile Assisted Learning

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Introduction

"Mobile phones are misnamed. They should be called gateways to human knowledge."

- Ray Kurzweil

Mobile Assisted Learning is the usage of mobile devices in order to enhance and support learning. It is the delivery of learning, education, or learning support on smartphones or other similar *mobile* devices.

Concepts of mobile assisted learning were introduced by Alan Kay in the 1970s when he joined Xerox Corporation's Palo Alto Research Center and formed a group to develop the "Dynabook," a portable and hands-on personal computer. The aim was to provide children with access to the digital world. However, this project eventually failed due to a lack of technological support at that time.

In 1994, Mitsubishi Electric Corp. created the first smartphone called IBM Simon, which was defined as a handheld personal communicator. Following this, various technological companies began designing what we now know as ***smartphones***. The creation of smartphones laid the foundation for mobile learning, and subsequent innovations in mobile devices propelled mobile learning into the realm of projects and research.

Future of Learning

"You can't teach people everything they need to know. The best you can do is position them where they can find what they need to know when they need to know it."

- Seymour Papert

Mobile Assisted Learning has altered the very landscape of learning, and mostly for the better. In many areas of education, the usage of mobile devices such as smartphones, tablets, and laptops have greatly improved the quality of learning.

The way in which knowledge is delivered to students has changed with time. Today, practical experience is prioritised more and more over traditional theoretical knowledge gaining, and mobile assisted learning has been a key contributor to this. With the help of these technological gadgets, the classroom experience has evolved, combining teaching with hands-on practice and making students understand what they learn better and better. Note-taking, accessing of relevant topics, organising the concepts learned have all seen major improvements with mobile assisted learning.

Let us look at some very interesting examples on how mobile assisted learning has completely improved education as a whole.

1) Computer Science students, who are allowed to use their smartphones or laptops in classes, can try the various programs taught in class then and there. They can practise and get a better understanding of the code they are dealing with, get used to the syntax better, and grow as a coder. Simply writing programs in a notebook is maybe useful, but this approach is definitely better. Students can achieve a more nuanced

understanding of different programming languages and other softwares when they get hands-on practice alongside the crucial guidance of a teacher.

2) Electronics students can use software applications like PSpice to construct complex circuits that might be too dangerous to practise in real-life, or might contain parts that are not available in the institution because of their scale or price. Whatever be the case, after some basic understanding of electronic components and circuits, students can experiment with the more complex ones in a safe and secure manner through these software applications, and be confident in implementing them later on.

3) Construction and other related work has also seen a spike in the usage of portable devices. Here as well, there are many software applications available to guide and make design planning easier. But of course, only after having a basic understanding of drawing principles and a concrete understanding of various simple and complex constructions, designs, and projections can a student properly implement them in a computer.

It is important to note that the technological gadgets used here are not *replacing* the traditional methods, but rather *adding on* to them. It is icing on an existing cake, and not an entirely new cake. That is why it is called Mobile *assisted* learning, and not just Mobile Learning. Technology is assisting, aiding the learning process and improving it, not taking over entirely. That is simply impossible.

Conclusion

It is obvious that there are many possible repercussions to mobile assisted learning. The usage of these devices in the classroom can often lead to distraction.

In a study by the University of Michigan Center for Research on Learning and Teaching (CRLT), which examined how in-class use of laptops affected student perceptions of their attentiveness, engagement, and learning, 75% of the students acknowledged that bringing their laptops to class increased the amount of time they spent on activities unrelated to learning, such as checking email and social networking. Furthermore, 40-46% of the students in the control group reported feeling "somewhat or significantly distracted" when other students seated near them were using laptops.

However, this particular obstacle is something that can be dealt with in an efficient manner. Distraction during learning is a problem that has been faced since the very beginning of learning, and the way in which distraction has evolved is concurrent with the way in which learning itself has progressed. Proper teaching techniques that manage to capture the attention of students is a necessity to tackling this. Not everyone can be up to this task, but that doesn't make it impossible.

Ultimately, mobile assisted learning is a modern way of learning that is slowly growing in importance, and it has the potential to bring forth a new educational revolution if taken in the right direction.

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